To Slay a Tiger

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The Cage

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Cheng's House, Ancient Zhu County

The cold sky presses down on black tiles. Black tiles press down on white walls.

At the foot of these walls is a courtyard. Though swept clean that morning, a light dusting of snow has already begun to reclaim it.

Chéng Héguāng carries firewood into the house and lights the stove.

Cheng Heguang: Copying documents at the Yamen still earns me around 30 wen a day.

He takes the ledger and inkstone down from a nearby shelf, dips his brush in ink, and carefully records the day's income and expenses.

Cheng Heguang: One bass sold for seven wen.

Cheng Heguang: Expenses: leaf celery, four wen. One jin of salt, five wen. Medicinal herbs, ten wen.

Cheng Heguang: Hm?

Someone steps lightly behind him and drapes a coat over his shoulders.

Mother: Back already? *cough* My, every winter feels colder than the last.

Cheng Heguang: You should be in bed. I only went to see Doctor Wú for some Baibu; he said you should be resting.

Mother: Alright, alright. But why did you go to him again? Don't you usually go to Jishitang?

Cheng Heguang: I wanted a new prescription. I heard he'd just made a new batch of Dazao pills.

Mother: Did you get some?

Cheng Heguang: ...

Mother: *sigh* I told you not to go there! In fact, I said we should've cut ties with him long ago.

Mother: Started up with his usual nonsense, did he? Refusing to let you inside, using some "illness" as an excuse? *cough, cough*

Chéng pauses for a moment and closes the ledger.

Cheng Heguang: It's no matter. I have the medicine. I'll start brewing it now.

Mother: What did he say?

Cheng Heguang: ...

At the doorway, the branches of a Mei tree shake off a few clumps of snow.

Thankfully for him, a sudden knock at the door interrupts the awkward silence.

Mother: Expecting someone?

Mother: We haven't had a visitor since your uncle returned to the countryside.

Chéng puts the ledger back on the shelf.

Cheng Heguang: I'll take a look.

Chéng trudges back through the snow to the courtyard gate and raises the latch.

A familiar military officer stands outside.

Cheng Heguang: Commander Lì?

Li Huifeng: Hmm. Héguāng, I hope I'm not intruding.

Cheng Heguang: Not at all. I just returned from the clinic and was preparing to brew some medicine.

Li Huifeng: How is your mother these days?

Cheng Heguang: Consumption is not easy to treat.

Cheng Heguang: Are you here on official Yamen business?

Lì Huìfēng offers a faint, amiable smile.

Li Huifeng: The Yamen's affairs have nothing to do with me.

Li Huifeng: I'm here to offer you an opportunity.

Cheng Heguang: ...!

Chéng returns indoors, clutching a yellowed sheet of paper.

The lid of the pot on the stove has already been lifted, the cooked rice porridge inside sending steady curls of steam into the air.

Out of habit, he takes the ladle from his mother's hand.

Cheng Heguang: Let me take care of this.

Mother: Who was it at the door, then?

Cheng Heguang: It was Commander Lì.

Chéng brings the porridge to the wooden table and casually passes the paper to his mother.

Cheng Heguang: Tomorrow, I'll ask if Auntie can come lend her hand for a while.

Cheng Heguang: It will be a long journey.

A few sparrows flit past the window, chirping as they flutter out of the courtyard.

Street, Riverside Village

This small village, governed by another county of Huanzhou Prefecture and nestled between mountains and rivers, has simply come to be called the Riverside Village.

This Riverside Village looks much like Zhu County. At its entrance, Chéng Héguāng sees the familiar rise and fall of black tiles once again.

Only, today's early afternoon is not quite as peaceful as usual.

Lead Villager: My brother's been mauled by a tiger! He's damn near on his deathbed! And you dogs have the gall to stand here, pushing us around?!

Cheng Heguang: ...?

To the left of the village entrance stands an exceptionally grand courtyard, with a memorial Paifang outside bearing the words "Loyalty, Filial Piety, Integrity, and Righteousness."

A group of villagers have gathered beneath the Paifang, their faces flushed as they shout at the household guards blocking their way.

Cheng Heguang: Likely the residence of a local gentry.

Chéng approaches without a word, slipping in among several bystanders.

Stern Guard: Doctor Xiù was paid for with the family's hard-earned silver! She's inside treating Master Hú. How dare you try to barge in!

Lead Villager: Doctor Xiù is the village physician, not the Hú family's private attendant!

Lead Villager: What could be more urgent than a life-or-death situation?! What right do you have to stop us? What are you hiding in there?

Lead Villager: Tell Doctor Xiù there's a patient out here on the verge of death! I know she'll come out to save him!

Stern Guard: You'll just have to find another doctor. If you set off now for the county, you can make it there before nightfall.

Lead Villager: We already hauled him all the way down the mountain to Doctor Xiù's clinic, only to be told she was here!

Lead Villager: Just look at him! Does he look as though he'll survive a trip to the county?!

The injured villager is slumped over his companion's back, his hastily bandaged left arm soaked with blood.

Stern Guard: That's none of our concern. We had no hand in his injuries.

Stern Guard: If you continue causing a scene outside Master Hú's house, we'll call the bailiff over to have you arrested!

The lead villager explodes in fury.

Lead Villager: Go on, call him! You're all in cahoots with one another anyway!

Lead Villager: Hú Hǎiyuè is so afraid of dying. He summons a doctor every time he nicks his skin.

Stern Guard: Watch your mouth, you slanderer!

Lead Villager: Our man's been mauled half to death, and you won't even let him through the door!

Calm Villager: They waited until land prices were low and took two acres of my land in exchange for just one tael of silver.

Disheartened Villager: Last year, I had a funeral to arrange and was desperate for money. The Hú family loaned it to me but charged five percent interest.

The lead villager snatches a bow from his companion's hands and aims it at the household guards. A wave of shock ripples through them.

Lead Villager: The Hú family's out to ruin us all! First they snatch up our fields, then they hound us with debt! They're driving us to death!

Lead Villager: Fellow villagers, tell me, does this sound fair to you?!

Villagers: No!

The rest of the villagers shout, their hoes and clubs raised high.

Lead Villager: We're done waiting! We're not taking it anymore!

Lead Villager: One way or another, I am going through that door!

Villagers: We'll not be pushed around! Burn down the gate! We'll force our way in!

The household guards draw their swords, raising their shields into a solid wall.

Stern Guard: Go ahead and try! This is nothing short of rebellion.

Before the words even finish leaving the guard's mouth, an arrow flies toward his forehead.

But before it can strike, it is cleaved in two by a flash of steel.

Chéng sheaths his blade, stepping between the guards and the villagers.

Cheng Heguang: This man is dying! What harm is there in letting him inside?

Stern Guard: Who are you?!

Calm Villager: He's not one of us.

The crowd exchanges glances like a theater troupe interrupted mid-performance, unsure of what to do next.

Stern Guard: You—

The gate is suddenly thrown open.

???: What is going on out there?!

The Tiger

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Calm, unhurried footsteps emerge from the courtyard.

Cheng Heguang: Seems they've had martial arts training.

The guards hastily make way, their voices softening with deference.

Stern Guard: D-Doctor Xiù, have you finished examining Master Hú?

Doctor Xiu: You mean his night blindness? Exactly how much time do you expect me to waste on that man?

Doctor Xiu: And you, out here making a racket and swinging your weapons about while I'm trying to write a prescription!

Doctor Xiu: Care to explain yourselves? Hm?

She takes the steps two at a time, passing Chéng without so much as a glance.

The villagers all lower their weapons, allowing her to approach the gravely injured man. She narrows her eyes as she examines him.

Doctor Xiu: How did this happen?

Disheartened Villager: We were hunting in the mountains and ran into a tiger. My brother, he fell behind and—

Before he can finish, Doctor Xiù turns and strides back toward the gate.

Doctor Xiu: Get him in here!

Stern Guard: But Doctor Xiù! He's covered in blood! How could we possibly carry him into Master Hú's courtyard?!

Doctor Xiu: It's bad luck for someone to die at the gate, is it not? I'll ask Master Hú for a room myself!

She pauses, then turns back impatiently.

Doctor Xiu: Well? Unless you wish for this man to die, I suggest you bring him in!

Lead Villager: Ah, r-right.

Lead Villager: Quickly, let's get him inside!

Two villagers rush the wounded man inside, streaking the entrance steps with blood as they ascend.

Cowardly Guard: Should we wipe it up? If it dries, it'll be harder to clean.

Stern Guard: Of course, you dolt! Unless you're looking for a scolding, you'll wipe it this instant!

The guards fetch water from the courtyard and begin hurriedly scrubbing Master Hú's steps.

Lead Villager: Hmph. Despicable!

Cheng Heguang: All's well that ends well, it seems.

Chéng is just about to leave when the lead villager steps in to block his path.

Lead Villager: Wait.

Lead Villager: Who are you? Why did you cut down my arrow?

Cheng Heguang: Only a passing traveler. Your arrow would never have pierced that guard's rattan shield, but it would have given them a reason to retaliate.

Cheng Heguang: Your recklessness will cause nothing but trouble.

Lead Villager: I may have lost my temper, but I've put up with them and their shoddy treatment for far too long to care about the consequences! If they fight, then we fight!

Cheng Heguang: And if you'd made the first move, you'd have been deemed the primary culprit. Were someone to die, your punishment would be death.

Lead Villager: And what of it?! You think I fear death?! Hah!

Lead Villager: The way you speak—it's obvious you come from noble stock. How could someone like you understand our struggles?

The disjointed back-and-forth frays Chéng's patience.

Cheng Heguang: I'm not—

During their exchange, several village guards rush over, stirring up a cloud of yellow dust under the Paifang.

Headman: What's going on here?!

Master Hú's personal guards hurry forward to greet them, directing their accusations at the villagers sitting cross-legged by the gate.

Stern Guard: It's these troublemakers! They've dirtied Master Hú's steps!

Calm Villager: We didn't mean to cause trouble. Someone was mauled by a tiger and urgently needed treatment!

Headman: Another tiger attack? We've lost three people this month to those beasts!

Headman: We have warned you over and over not to travel into the mountains. Why go up there?

Lead Villager: With this year's feeble harvest, what choice did we have? Five years ago it was floods, and now it's drought! Grain has grown more expensive than gold!

Lead Villager: If we don't hunt, what are we to eat?

Calm Villager: My land has all been taken, and we have no grain stored for the winter. Hunting rabbits is the only way we can scrape together a half-decent meal.

Disheartened Villager: If only ... If only an immortal would appear again, as they did five years ago, handing out grain to us all.

After a moment's hesitation, Chéng steps past the village guards and offers the headman a modest bow.

Cheng Heguang: I've had some formal weapons training, including hand-to-hand. If you aim to head into the mountains to hunt the tiger, I will offer my assistance.

The village guards exchange amused glances.

Headman: That mountain forest isn't meant for travel. Only a fool would go there without a good reason. Had these hunters not been so greedy, this wouldn't have happened.

Headman: The tiger attacked them in the forest, not the village. We can't go traipsing into the forest hunting tigers. We'd never get any real work done!

With a dismissive wave, he turns back to scold the grime-covered villagers.

Headman: That's enough! Go back to your homes! And no one is to go up the mountain again!

Cheng Heguang: Your decree doesn't change the fact that these hunters still have families to feed.

Cheng Heguang: That tiger has taken too many lives. It cannot be ignored.

The headman suddenly swings his staff as if he were swatting at an annoying mosquito. Its tip brushes inches from the hem of Chéng's clothes.

Headman: You're getting on my last nerve, boy!

Headman: You are neither an official nor a member of this village. What good does it serve you to stick your nose into our business?

Headman: If you're so eager to play the hero, go deal with the tiger yourself.

Broken cries echo from the courtyard. Chéng tightens his grip on the hilt of his blade.

Cheng Heguang: This is absurd.

He pushes past the guards, once again placing himself between them and the villagers.

Headman: Hey! What do you think you're doing?!

Cheng Heguang: The tiger. Can you tell me exactly where you encountered it?

Mountaintop, Riverside Village

Cheng Heguang: Enter the forest and head due south. After passing another slope, it is somewhere near the edge of the cliff.

Cheng Heguang: They said the tiger is blue and white, two or three times larger than an ordinary one. It almost sounds like a monster.

Ahead stretches a thick pine forest with shrubs reaching up to the knee. Wild grass lies flattened in the undergrowth, streaked with dull, rust-red blood.

Cheng Heguang: This is where the hunter was wounded. I should proceed with caution.

The forest wind falls silent, and the wild grass rustles softly.

The sound of heavy breathing reaches Chéng's ears.

Cheng Heguang: It's sneaked behind me!

A massive tiger, blue streaks in its magnificent white fur, bursts from the grass, slamming Chéng to the ground.

He braces his half-drawn blade across his chest, barely holding off the attack.

Blue flames flare across the tiger's brow as it presses its claws against the blade.

Tiger: *roar*

Cheng Heguang: That's some strength, hah!

A feather shoots from his shoulder guard like an arrow, piercing the tiger's forehead.

Tiger: Graaargh!

A thunderous roar shakes the forest. In an attempt to escape, the tiger clamps its jaws around Chéng's blade and hauls him forward.

Chéng refuses to let go as the tiger barrels forward, rushing them both to a nearby cliff edge.

Cheng Heguang: No!

As the tiger leaps, a sudden sense of weightlessness comes over Chéng.

In a split second, he grabs hold of the cliff edge, his body dangling below.

Cheng Heguang: Urgh!

One, two, three ... Feather after feather pierces downward.

With the final impact, the tiger's grip loosens. It lets out a final howl as it plummets down into the ravine below and vanishes out of sight.

Cheng Heguang: Phew!

Cheng Heguang: The soil is too loose. It needs to be harder if I'm to pull myself up.

Cheng Heguang: Breathe. Sense the flow of Qi. Wherever it touches, the earth hardens like iron.

Cheng Heguang: Concentrate ...

The soil beneath his fingers takes on a faint metallic sheen but doesn't spread any further.

Cheng Heguang: Is it too much for me to handle?

Cheng Heguang: ...!

As the soil's binding begins to fail, the clump in his grip begins to break apart.

A pale fog blankets the foot of the cliff. Falling would surely mean his demise.

Even so, he feels his grip beginning to falter.

Cheng Heguang: Darn it!

A heartbeat before his fingers give out, a thin silver thread slices through the air from the cliff edge.

Cheng Heguang: That's—!

The Old Friend

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Mountaintop, Riverside Village

The silver thread coils around Chéng's waist and drags him back onto the cliff.

He hits the ground and rolls, the stabbing pain in his left leg catching up to him on impact.

A broken branch is lodged in his calf.

The village doctor stands over him, calmly reeling the silver thread back onto a bone shuttle.

Cheng Heguang: It's you!

Doctor Xiu: Playing the lone hero isn't a healthy habit.

Cheng Heguang: It's how I usually get things done.

Cheng Heguang: Someone had to resolve the matter. Agh. Besides, once I see a problem, I cannot turn a blind eye to it.

Cheng Heguang: I couldn't involve those hunters again, not after they scarcely made it back alive.

Doctor Xiu: How can you be so sure they wouldn't have lent a hand?

Doctor Xiù steps closer, squatting down and inspecting the wound on his left leg.

Doctor Xiu: Good news: it doesn't appear too deep.

Doctor Xiu: Are you ready?

She doesn't wait for an answer. In one swift motion, she yanks the branch free, and the wound wells with blood.

Cheng Heguang: Tch.

Satisfied there are no splinters left in the wound, Doctor Xiù guides her silver thread through a series of precise sutures.

With practiced ease, she applies herbs pulled from her robes to the wound, then cuts and ties a clean white bandage.

Cheng Heguang: Thank you. You've quite the unique method for treating wounds.

Doctor Xiu: Ah, I just find some joy in experimenting with my arcane skill.

Cheng Heguang: ...

Cheng Heguang: Forgive my bluntness, but what are you doing here, Doctor?

Doctor Xiu: The Hú family refused to let the hunter stay after I patched him up, so I had him taken to my clinic. Whether he survives or not is in fate's hands now.

Doctor Xiu: In any case, it struck me that you looked somewhat familiar.

Doctor Xiu: I asked around where you'd gone and was promptly informed that you'd inquired about the tiger's whereabouts and run off alone. To face the beast, no doubt.

Doctor Xiu: "That can't be!" I told them, but their faces were deadly serious. I was worried something might happen, so I hurried over.

Doctor Xiù falls silent, her eyes lingering on Chéng.

Doctor Xiu: If not for your lack of familiarity with the terrain, your getting lost notwithstanding, I doubt I'd have been able to catch up to you in time.

Cheng Heguang: It wasn't all that dangerous, although the tiger was fiercer than I had anticipated.

Doctor Xiu: Hah, the recklessness of youth.

Doctor Xiu: May I know your name?

Cheng Heguang: Chéng Héguāng.

Doctor Xiu: I must say, Chéng Héguāng, that flying-feather technique of yours is quite curious. A skill passed down through your family, I presume?

Cheng Heguang: That's right.

Doctor Xiù's winding of the bandage falters for an instant before she finishes up and knots it.

Doctor Xiu: I once knew a man by the name of Chéng. He commanded flying metal shards through the air. His abilities were quite impressive.

Doctor Xiu: Still, those who excel in such things tend to have weaker constitutions.

Doctor Xiu: He used to be on the wrong side of the law, but "official" was written into both his name and his fate. And sure enough, in the end, he became one.

Doctor Xiu: Did you know him?

Chéng clenches his teeth, his focus shifting to the remaining flying feathers on his shoulder.

Cheng Heguang: I can see you've discerned it already. He was my father.

Finished with the bandaging, Doctor Xiù stands up and dusts off her hands.

Doctor Xiu: Oh! Well, that's quite the coincidence!

Doctor Xiu: Your father and I were friends. Which, I suppose, makes you my nephew, or near enough.

Doctor Xiu: So listen, nephew: this injury will take a few days to heal, and the dressing will need changing. My clinic is at the foot of the mountain. Come stay with me for a few days.

Cheng Heguang: Thank you.

Cheng Heguang: I brought little money with me. I'm afraid I may not have enough to cover the medical expenses for the next few days.

Doctor Xiu: You think I'm after a few coins? Just stay. You can pay me back by lending me your hand when you can.

Doctor Xiu: Might I lend you mine in getting up?

Cheng Heguang: No need. I can manage.

Doctor Xiu: The two set off together down the mountain.

Doctor Xiu: You seem young. Are you still studying, or have you already become an official?

Cheng Heguang: Neither. I mostly get by on odd jobs.

Doctor Xiu: And what "odd job" brought you to this poor place in the middle of nowhere?

Cheng Heguang: I was running an errand for someone and happened to pass through.

Doctor Xiu: I see. How is your mother?

Cheng Heguang: Well enough.

Doctor Xiu: Hmm. And your father?

Cheng Heguang: He passed away.

Doctor Xiu: What happened?

Cheng Heguang: He had an accident.

Doctor Xiu: I'm sorry. I never would have imagined.

Cheng Heguang: Imagined?

Doctor Xiu: Mhm. He was still young. But, I suppose death comes for us all.

A long silence falls.

Foot of Mountain, Riverside Village

Reaching the foot of the mountain, they push through the grass and follow the stream for a short distance.

From between the trees, a solitary white house emerges into view.

Cheng Heguang: Why set up a clinic out here in the wilderness? It would be easier to see patients if you lived in the village.

Doctor Xiu: Convenient, sure. But the houses in the village are tall and crammed together one after another. Living like that would be maddening.

Cheng Heguang: But your clinic has the same black roof tiles and white walls. It looks no different from the houses in Zhu County or the village.

Doctor Xiu: What do you expect me to do, paint the house black from top to bottom?

Doctor Xiù whirls, sending three silver threads like spider silk toward Chéng's vital joints.

As if he'd anticipated the attack, Chéng dodges. Flying feathers clash with silver threads, tangling as they fall to the ground.

Cheng Heguang: What was that?!

Doctor Xiu: Ah, you could have stood and taken the threads, yet you chose to dodge and tear the wound open instead.

Cheng Heguang: ...?

Doctor Xiu: Your command over your arcane skill is undisciplined, to say the least. Had you used it properly earlier, you'd have subdued the tiger without so much as a scratch.

Doctor Xiù shakes her head and sighs.

Doctor Xiu: I remember how your father would turn leaves to metal, sending them flying as he bid. There are plenty of leaves here. Why not give it a try?

Cheng Heguang: ...

Cheng Heguang: I can't.

Cheng Heguang: Everyone from my clan can control light metals, but transmutation ... I am the only one left who can do it. Or at least, I ought to be.

Doctor Xiu: You've chosen not to use this unique ability?

Cheng Heguang: Not exactly.

Cheng Heguang: I can no longer control it, as if something is blocking me. As a child, I used it recklessly. It caused an accident. After that, with no one to guide me, I dared not use it often.

Doctor Xiu: A waste, if you ask me. Only you possess this ability, and yet you shackle yourself with hesitation.

Doctor Xiu: Your father and I sparred many times, enough for me to become familiar with his arcane skill.

Doctor Xiu: His arcane skill, like mine, relied on guiding matter with Qi. If you wish it, I can teach you a few techniques. Be a guide of sorts.

Cheng Heguang: But why?

Doctor Xiu: Why? Because I want to, and because it's the right thing to do.

Cheng Heguang: But ...

Doctor Xiu: Chéng Héguāng, when an elder offers you her teachings, you shut your mouth and listen.

Main Room, Clinic

Doctor Xiù swings open the clinic door without ceremony.

Inside the clinic, an assistant is busy boiling medicine. Two or three patients lie resting nearby, including the hunter whose arm was mauled earlier.

Assistant: Doctor, you're back! Who's this?

Doctor Xiu: A patient I picked up on the road. How's the hunter?

Assistant: He's still unconscious.

Doctor Xiu: Alright. Be sure to change his dressing in a couple of hours and keep a close eye on him tonight. A fever could prove fatal.

One of the patients, a young man, hops out of bed and runs over, his face flushed with color.

Young Man: Doctor! That medicine's incredible! I've never felt so alive, like I could plow two acres of land without so much as a breath!

Doctor Xiu: I'm glad to hear—

Old Man: Doctor! Help! Help!

Doctor Xiù lets out a weary sigh and walks over to the old man's bed.

Doctor Xiu: What is it this time?

Old Man: I still feel terribly ill. My stomach hurts, and I throw up every time I eat.

Doctor Xiu: I gave you strict instructions not to have any food! But you just couldn't help yourself, could you?

Assistant: Uh. I've just brewed him some fresh medicine. I only poured it a moment ago. It's still hot.

Doctor Xiu: To the assistant's surprise, Doctor Xiù smiles and looks up at Chéng, who is still standing by the door.

Doctor Xiu: Perfect. We have just the man for handling a little heat.

Cheng Heguang: ...?

The Silver Thread

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Doctor Xiu: Now, Chéng, move the bowl of medicine on the table into my hand using only your family's technique.

Cheng Heguang: Why?

Doctor Xiu: Do you often make a habit of arguing with your elders?

Cheng Heguang: ...

Doctor Xiu: Brewing and serving medicine is part of the clinic's duties. But, if you'd prefer to lie around and take advantage of my hospitality for the next few days, be my guest.

Chéng falls silent for a moment, then extends his right hand and aims it at the bowl of medicine.

Cheng Heguang: Urgh. Hngh!

In an instant, the medicine bowl turns black and spins forward, almost crashing into Doctor Xiù's hand.

Doctor Xiu: Hmm. A little excessive, but all in all, not bad for a first try.

Doctor Xiu: Although, it is rather heavy. I wonder why.

Doctor Xiu: Hahahaha!

She breaks into a cheerful laugh, then props the metal bowl upright and shows it to Chéng.

The medicinal broth inside the bowl has been transmuted along with it, becoming a solid block of metal.

Doctor Xiu: Fortunately, the effect wears off in time; otherwise, you'd be paying for the medicine.

Doctor Xiu: Have patience. Remember, a single day does not make a master.

Old Man: Owww!

Cheng Heguang: It's been a long while since I've used it so much.

Cheng Heguang: With a little more practice, I know I will perform it without error.

Doctor Xiù retrieves several chipped, broken bowls from around the room.

Doctor Xiu: Well, you're not lacking for confidence. Why not begin with these? Once you've mastered them, lighter things like flowers and leaves should be no problem at all.

Doctor Xiu: Your arcane skill works much like my own, simple, really. Sense the flow of Qi, carefully straighten it, and aim it at the object.

Doctor Xiu: And strike.

Cheng Heguang: Hyah!

The metal bowl slams into the wall once again, and Chéng's brow knots even tighter.

Hunter: Young man, I have watched you throw that broken bowl around day after day, and I still can't fathom why Doctor Xiù is making you do it.

Having woken up with little else to occupy him, the tiger-bitten hunter has decided to strike up a conversation with Chéng.

Cheng Heguang: I'm training my arcane skill.

Unable to resist, the remaining two bedridden patients chime in as well.

Old Man: Training? That old lady can't even throw a punch. What, does she think she's some sort of martial arts master now?

Cheng Heguang: What do you mean "can't throw a punch"?

Young Man: Haha! Did she catch you off guard too?

Young Man: She looks fierce, has a bad temper, and talks loud enough to rattle the bedpans, but I've never once seen Doctor Xiù get into a fight with anyone.

Old Man: Her arcane skill, those silver threads of hers, is finer than hair. Other than stitching up wounds, what good could they be?

Cheng Heguang: The thought hadn't occurred to me.

Hunter: Come now, you can hardly say that! At the Dushuo Festival, Doctor Xiù played a female soldier, remember? "Kill! Kill!" She was like a demoness, fierce as anything!

Young Man: Come on, anyone can shout! I could just as well play a great general! "All troops, heed my command!"

Another metal bowl rolls onto the floor.

Cheng Heguang: Still, I hear there was once a bandit in Huanzhou who fought with silver threads.

Cheng Heguang: They say the bandit stole state supplies, torched villages, and left many soldiers wounded.

Old Man: I've heard traveling merchants talk about the very same thing. They say those silver threads could cut through iron like mud. Frightening stuff.

Old Man: In the end, the bandit raided Zhu County. But, after that, word of them vanished.

Young Man: Zhu County?! That's the richest place in all of Huanzhou! All manner of merchants and officials live there.

Young Man: Not like this poor backwater town we're stuck in.

Hunter: Nonsense! Doctor Xiù would never stoop to being some lowly mountain bandit! If she could fight, she'd be a hero!

Young Man: Plenty of people have similar arcane skills, don't they? I can produce flames from my fingertips, just like the Hú family!

Old Man: I suppose you're right. I've never seen her use those silver threads for anything practical, not even to slice a vegetable. Perhaps they simply aren't good for much!

Hunter: You could walk every street of the village saying she's a bandit, and I bet not a soul would believe it.

Cheng Heguang: Is that so?

Old Man: There was a time we didn't have a doctor in the village. Small illnesses, we just had to endure, and we couldn't afford the county fees for anything serious.

Old Man: After Doctor Xiù arrived, the villagers could finally get the treatment they needed.

Young Man: That's right. My son was having convulsions last year. It's thanks to her that he's still with us.

Cheng Heguang: ...

The metal bowl slowly rises, wobbling as it drifts toward the other side of the room.

Finally, it settles smoothly on the table.

Cheng Heguang: ...!

Hunter: Well done, young man! It's about time you finally managed it!

Old Man: Now maybe you can get my medicine over here without spilling it!

Doctor Xiu: Ah, the Hú family's calling me over for medicine again! Ever sending their orders, yet never bothering to actually come to the clinic!

Doctor Xiu: I swear, the day I end up saving their lives is the day I squeeze ten thousand taels out of them!

Assistant: Go ahead, Doctor. I'll keep an eye on the clinic.

Doctor Xiù is halfway across the threshold when a teacup suddenly spins in from behind, aimed at her side.

Assistant: Doctor!

Doctor Xiù doesn't even flinch. She reaches out her hand, and the teacup halts in midair before slowly dropping into her palm.

The cup's base gleams with a clean metallic sheen. The tea inside is perfectly brewed, the leaves fully unfurled and settled at the bottom.

Cheng Heguang: So?

Doctor Xiu: To have come this far in just three days! Your progress is indeed worthy of praise.

Doctor Xiù drains the tea in one gulp, then steps out the door.

Side Room, Clinic

In the early hours of the morning, while the patients are still sleeping, Chéng Héguāng gathers the broken bowls together.

The doctor's assistant walks over carrying a bowl of medicinal broth.

Assistant: Time for your medicine, young man.

Cheng Heguang: Hm? I don't recall Doctor Xiù prescribing me any additional medication.

Assistant: It's a new prescription, designed to help replenish your Qi.

Cheng Heguang: Smells like Huangqi and Danggui. But my injury is already healed. There's no use wasting good medicine.

Assistant: You still need to make up for your Qi and blood loss. The doctor specially prescribed it for you.

Chéng frowns slightly but still takes the medicine and raises it to his lips.

A silver thread shoots in and knocks the medicine bowl from his hand.

It shatters with a sharp crack. Brown medicinal liquid splashes across the floor.

Doctor Xiù stands nearby with a hardened expression.

Doctor Xiu: That is not what I prescribed.

Assistant: Doctor! You've returned already?!

Doctor Xiu: I came back for something. What's going on here?

Assistant: This new patient of yours, he's up to something.

The assistant pulls a pale yellow sheet of paper from his jacket and hands it to Doctor Xiù.

Cheng Heguang: Did you go through my bag?!

Assistant: Regular visitors don't inquire about bandits at a clinic. You covered your tracks well, but not well enough!

Doctor Xiu: Let's see here. "The bandit known as 'Shuttlebones,' bearing arms in public, robbed the prefectural granary ..."

Doctor Xiu: "The offender is a violent bandit who wields a bone shuttle and silver thread with deadly precision. All jurisdictions are commanded to conduct the arrest with extreme vigilance."

Doctor Xiu: So this is the warrant for my arrest? My, my, look how hideous this drawing of me is. Who would even recognize me from such a scrawl? I suppose it was my arcane skill that gave me away, wasn't it?

Cheng Heguang: ...

Assistant: I'm sorry, Doctor. I wanted to deal with this before you returned.

Doctor Xiù folds the arrest warrant in half and tosses it into the nearby brazier.

Doctor Xiu: Our curious patient here is Brother Chéng's child.

Assistant: Heh, I had my suspicions with that arcane skill of his.

Assistant: But so what if he is?! We helped Chéng Dàoguān when he needed it most. His son ought to help us in return! Besides, you've done nothing wrong!

Assistant: My daughter was starving to death while he dragged his feet every step of the way, acting the young lord. If it weren't you—

Doctor Xiù slams her palm down on the table beside her.

Doctor Xiu: Enough! There's medicine that needs boiling.

Doctor Xiu: Go!

The assistant casts an unwilling glance at Chéng, then leaves in sullen silence.

Doctor Xiù suddenly sweeps the metallized broken bowls to the floor.

Cheng Heguang: ...!

Doctor Xiu: You said you're not with the Yamen.

Cheng Heguang: I am not. But on occasion, I take bounty orders from them.

Doctor Xiu: Ah, your "odd jobs." Is it the money you care for? Or is it something else?

Doctor Xiu: Why not confront me directly? Waiting for me to nurse you to health first? Planning to slit my throat in the night?

Cheng Heguang: I've watched you for days. Nothing about you resembles a criminal.

Cheng Heguang: That warrant means nothing to me.

Cheng Heguang: If you swear to me that you never committed arson, hurt anyone, or raided Zhu County, then I will leave at once.

Doctor Xiù draws in a slow breath, her face returning to its usual calm.

Doctor Xiu: But I did it all.

Doctor Xiu: Your injury's healed, hasn't it?

Doctor Xiu: Let's get started.

The Flying Leaves

CH34701-05

Mother: Shuttlebones ... I remember her. She knew your father once.

Cheng Heguang: Yes. The Yamen has confirmed she was the ringleader behind the raid on Zhu County that night.

Cheng Heguang: All those caught in that raid were executed, save for her. She fled with a handful of others, disappearing near the Riverside Village.

Cheng Heguang: If she yet lives after all these years, she has likely lowered her guard and settled into an ordinary life.

Cheng Heguang: If I resolve this, I'll have amassed enough merit to fill the opening for the constable. And the reward sum will surely help us in the meantime.

Mother: You'll finally have some standing, and those brutes at the Yamen won't push you around any longer. *cough, cough*

Mother: Your father told me a little about Shuttlebones before. She is powerful, a reliable ally, and a formidable foe.

Cheng Heguang: I'll be careful. Besides, there are few anywhere in Huanzhou Prefecture who can match the blade techniques you taught me.

Mother: Haha. That's good to hear.

Mother: I worry that you're pushing yourself too hard.

Chéng takes his sword down from the wall.

Cheng Heguang: No need to worry.

Cheng Heguang: This is what I've always wanted, and it's the only right way forward.

Foot of Mountain, Riverside Village

Amid a clearing in the mountain woods, Chéng stands peering up at the trees.

Cheng Heguang: So this is what you meant by a duel?

Doctor Xiù perches with one leg propped on a tree branch, calmly twirling the bone shuttle in her hand.

Doctor Xiu: This is how I toyed with Yamen officers when I was young. You should never expect an enemy to fight on your terms.

Cheng Heguang: So be it.

Chéng draws his blade, cleaving the high branch in a single strike.

Doctor Xiu: Hmph. That's what they used to do, too.

A silver thread shoots out from the swaying leaves, carrying Doctor Xiù safely to the high branches of another tree.

Doctor Xiu: Never worked back then either.

Chéng sends several leaves shooting upward. They fall short before reaching their mark.

Doctor Xiu: You're wasting your energy. I know your arcane skill cannot reach so high.

Cheng Heguang: Then I'll drag you back down!

The sword whirls in his hands, the force trembling the surrounding pines.

After several moments, Doctor Xiù cannot help but sigh.

Doctor Xiu: Ah, you foolish boy. Tell me, what do you believe this will achieve?

Doctor Xiu: This little thread of mine can go very far. Allow me to demonstrate.

A longer silver thread extends from her outstretched arm, propelling her toward a distant tree.

Doctor Xiu: Hmm?

The silver thread snaps, sending her hurtling back to the ground.

Two metal leaves fall from the air in her wake.

Doctor Xiu: Nicely done.

Cheng Heguang: When you swing between the trees, you lose some height. How much you drop depends on the length of the silver thread.

Cheng Heguang: No matter how long your thread, my arcane skill will be able to reach you.

Chéng braces his blade before him.

Cheng Heguang: Are you ready to finish this?

Doctor Xiù turns her back and begins to amble off along the mountain path.

Doctor Xiu: No, I'm tired now.

Chéng stares at her back, confused, before deciding to follow after her.

Cheng Heguang: If you never meant to fight, why challenge me? Why lure me here?

Doctor Xiu: Why the hurry? You can't be sure you'll beat me, can you? Ever heard of keeping your blade sheathed and waiting for the perfect moment to strike?

Doctor Xiu: And even if you were to win, what then?

Cheng Heguang: I would take you to the Yamen.

Doctor Xiu: The very moment you defeat me?

Cheng Heguang: No. Not until every patient in the clinic is healed.

Doctor Xiu: Then you'll be waiting for a long time! Over a thousand people live in that Riverside Village. Three days don't pass without someone knocking at the door!

Doctor Xiu: Besides, there are still some patients in the clinic right now, are there not? So what's the rush? We'll come back to this tomorrow.

The Next Day

Doctor Xiu: Fallen leaves scatter, turning into metallic blades as they tangle with silver thread.

They streak through the air in a blur, impossible to make out.

Doctor Xiu: You're improving quickly. Most struggle to see my thread, let alone defend against it.

Cheng Heguang: Still not fast enough. I can't catch the silver thread's Qi. I can't turn it into metal.

Cheng Heguang: You're shielding the bone shuttle in your grip. Its Qi resistance is too strong. I can't properly use my arcane skill.

Doctor Xiu: I can't allow you to destroy my weapon that quickly. I have a reputation to uphold.

Several blackened silver threads coil around the edge of Chéng's blade.

Doctor Xiu: You rely too much on your arcane skill. Your metallization is irreversible. You've even trapped your own blade.

Cheng Heguang: ...

Doctor Xiu: As the silver thread whips around Chéng's neck, the wild grass beneath Doctor Xiù's feet lashes upward in stabbing arcs.

Doctor Xiu: The blades of grass halt at her throat.

Doctor Xiu: ...!

Doctor Xiu: Handling so many at once. I underestimated you.

Cheng Heguang: Urgh. Let's call it a draw.

Doctor Xiu: Fine.

Doctor Xiu: We'll stop here for today.

Yard, Clinic

After some hours of training in the woods, Chéng returns to the clinic a little late.

Several villagers are helping the hunter as he heads home. When he spots Chéng, he raises a hand in greeting.

Hunter: I'm on the mend and ready to head home. Doctor Xiù has plenty of work to do. Last thing she needs is me taking up more of her time.

Hunter: I heard you killed that tiger! Why didn't you tell me sooner? I'll head back to the village and let everyone know!

Cheng Heguang: I only did what was necessary. No need to make a fuss.

The man doesn't hear a word, only shuffling off with a foolish grin on his face.

Chéng enters the clinic to find Doctor Xiù seated by the medicine stove, gently fanning the flames.

A few days earlier, Doctor Xiù sent her assistant to prepare medicine for the Hú household. Now it is only the two of them.

Cheng Heguang: With such skills in medicine, why become a bandit?

Doctor Xiu: Because I wanted to be a hero.

Cheng Heguang: Righteous ends must be pursued through righteous means. However they justify it, bandits inevitably bring harm to the innocent.

Doctor Xiu: There's no reasoning with someone as immovable as you. Distributing the grain I'd stolen from the officials to the poor—that is a life worth living!

Cheng Heguang: And robbing the people of Zhu County? Is that your idea of heroism?

Doctor Xiù keeps her eyes on the medicine stove, seemingly oblivious to Chéng's words.

A long silence passes before she replies.

Doctor Xiu: No. I know I don't have the stuff to be a hero. But, living here and being a doctor respected by the people? That I can do.

Doctor Xiu: Tell me, what happened to your father?

Cheng Heguang: You didn't know?

Doctor Xiu: Sorry, I was running for my life back then, too busy pretending to be something I'm not, hah.

She chuckles with a trace of self-mockery.

Doctor Xiu: And after that, well, I settled into a life of black tiles and white walls. Every day filled with the simple chatterings of villagers and patients, knowing nothing of the outside world.

Cheng Heguang: I told you he passed away.

Cheng Heguang: He confessed to his crimes and accepted his punishment.

Doctor Xiu: I see.

Doctor Xiu: ...

Doctor Xiù lifts the lid of the medicine pot and peers inside. In an instant, the clinic fills with the bitter scent of herbs.

Cheng Heguang: The villagers speak so highly of your medical skills. Do you know anything about treating consumption? Any special remedies?

Doctor Xiu: What are the symptoms? How long has it been?

Cheng Heguang: It began the winter before last. At first there was only coughing and night sweats, but the cough worsened rapidly.

Cheng Heguang: Over the past three months, she's been coughing up blood quite frequently, suffering severe chest pain, and often says she has trouble breathing.

Doctor Xiu: There's nothing I can do.

Cheng Heguang: The doctors in Zhu County said the same.

Doctor Xiu: They were right. I'm afraid she won't make it through the year.

Doctor Xiu: I'm assuming she's someone special to you?

Without a word, Chéng turns his back and leaves the clinic.

After a while, the medicine in the pot begins to bubble over.

Doctor Xiu: Chéng Héguāng, pass me the ladle!

Doctor Xiu: Chéng Héguāng!

Hearing no response, Doctor Xiù steps away from the stove and heads outside.

Foot of Mountain, Riverside Village

A small patch of grass grows just outside the clinic.

Now, that grass is a weapon. Every leaf has been turned into a blade, whirling in tight clusters on the wind.

They dart through the wind, striking one another with a sharp, metallic clang.

Cheng Heguang: This is unfair.

Doctor Xiu: It is. But remember, Chéng: flowers bloom and fade, grass withers and thrives. All is governed by the Lord of Spring.

Cheng Heguang: I'd never have expected such words from you.

Doctor Xiu: Hah. I'm from a medical family. Just a handful of verses picked up in my youth, that's all.

Doctor Xiu: Not fond of that kind of talk?

The needle-fine metal shards freeze in midair, then scatter across the ground.

Cheng Heguang: I'll clean this up.

Doctor Xiu: You've cleaned enough. You should head home.

Cheng Heguang: I'm not done here.

Doctor Xiu: Yes, well, we can take care of that tomorrow.

The Night Raid

CH34701-06

Chéng sits on a mat, tending to his sword. The blade catches the light as it turns, casting a few bright reflections into Doctor Xiù's wine bowl.

Doctor Xiu: *sigh* Always wound so tight. The real showdown is tomorrow, so why not relax a little? There'll be no coming back from this one.

Cheng Heguang: I clean my weapon every night and reflect on the day's deeds. One must restrain oneself and submit to proper conduct.

Doctor Xiu: Of course. Forget I said anything.

Cheng Heguang: It is precisely because I'm dueling you that I must prepare all the more.

Doctor Xiu: Do you truly need the money so dearly? Is that why you're so set on defeating me?

Cheng Heguang: It's not about the money. Fulfilling this task will give me a chance at a constable's posting.

Doctor Xiu: Ah. So you need credentials, then.

Cheng Heguang: The circumstances of my birth limit my avenues into court.

Doctor Xiù takes another sip of her wine.

Doctor Xiu: The court again! Why does everyone have such great desires to hold office?

Doctor Xiu: Your father said the same thing once. He told me I was not to come looking for him again, saying, "You and I are no longer the same. I am an official now. I have a life in Zhu County."

Doctor Xiu: I said to him, "People must eat, must they not? Floods have brought ruin to the fields, and children are starving." But did he listen?

Doctor Xiu: I didn't ask much of him. Just to leave a door open for us, and we'd make it worth his while—

Cheng Heguang: I know the story.

Cheng Heguang: "Case Record: Chéng Dàoguān, garrison officer of Zhu County, on account of personal ties, led bandits into the city and permitted the plundering of the county granaries; further charges include accepting bribes. All statements are entered on record."

Cheng Heguang: After the bandits entered the city, they not only looted the granaries but also vandalized and ransacked nearby homes, drawing the people into their violence. That night, 24 people were killed or injured.

Cheng Heguang: "In the evening, Commander Chéng instructed us to change shifts early. We were unaware of any looting. I swear that this given statement is true."

Cheng Heguang: When the bandits ransacked the surrounding areas, there were no officers nearby to hear the people's cries for help.

Cheng Heguang: Am I wrong?

Doctor Xiu: They weren't always bandits. They were once refugees, those who had lost their land and couldn't get enough to eat.

Cheng Heguang: What difference does that make?!

Cheng Heguang: Talking on this further is pointless.

Chéng sheaths his blade and steps out of the clinic before Doctor Xiù can reply.

The night grows hazy, draping a faint veil over the trees in the forest.

Cheng Heguang: ...

Cheng Heguang: What was I expecting?

Cheng Heguang: Some hidden, nonexistent truth?

Chéng leaves the dirt road and turns into the forest. Along the path's edge, the darkening grass and shrubs bow away to either side.

Layer by layer, the dense, overlapping branches part as he moves deeper into the forest's embrace.

Cheng Heguang: There was no hidden truth, no injustice, just a transaction, one that may even have helped the refugees.

Cheng Heguang: But your duty was to protect the people of Zhu County. How could you sacrifice their lives?!

Cheng Heguang: You should have thought about your actions, stopped to think what could have—

He stops in his tracks.

It's a clearing in the forest, a tiger crouching at its center.

Cheng Heguang: ...!

Enormous and beautiful, the tiger bears a silent blue flame upon its brow, its fur shimmering like moonlit silk.

Chéng recognizes a familiar wound on its forehead.

Cheng Heguang: That's the same tiger that attacked me a few days ago! But I saw it fall from the cliff with my own eyes.

The tiger pays no attention to him. Instead, it stretches its neck, lets out a deep, resounding call, and springs forward to the north.

Cheng Heguang: That's the direction of the clinic!

Cheng Heguang: Hold there!

Chéng Héguāng clenches his fists, sending dozens of blades after the tiger.

They converge on it in an instant, only to ricochet outward, bursting apart like fireworks.

Cheng Heguang: What on ...?!

He tries once more, but the blades are again knocked away. It seems the tiger's fur is tougher than any steel.

It isn't long before the tiger arrives at the clinic, Chéng in close pursuit. He can only watch as it brings down the south wall with a single strike.

Cheng Heguang: Doctor Xiù, watch out!

The tiger lifts its front paws high, then freezes.

Hair-thin silver threads lace around it, binding it like a fly in a web.

Inside the half-collapsed house, Doctor Xiù grips her bone shuttle, placing herself in front of the collapsed hunter clinging to a small wooden container.

Cheng Heguang: What are you doing here?!

Hunter: I-I came to deliver this chicken soup. We cooked a big pot of it at home earlier tonight!

Hunter: This wasn't me! I didn't lead the tiger here! I had thought it dead already!

Doctor Xiu: Chéng Héguāng! Get him out of here! This beast is too strong!

Her words and body shake with the effort of holding the tiger in place.

Chéng leaps in behind her and swiftly lifts the hunter to his feet.

Cheng Heguang: Get up! Run!

Tiger: ...

Tiger: Graaargh!

Doctor Xiu: ...!

The tiger tenses, and a second later, the silver threads snap.

Hunter: AAAHHH!

Amid a burst of dust and debris, Chéng grabs the hunter and rolls aside.

When the dust clears, the clinic lies in ruins, and Doctor Xiù is nowhere to be seen. The tiger stalks toward Chéng, a severed right arm clenched in its jaws.

Tiger: *roar*

Chéng catches a glimpse of Doctor Xiù's bone shuttle glinting between the tiger's fangs before it disappears down its throat.

Cheng Heguang: Get out of here! Now! Go back and find the village headman!

Hunter: What about you?

Cheng Heguang: I will deal with it.

Cheng Heguang: But first, I must get in closer. Much closer.

The hunter flees at full speed as the tiger lunges toward Chéng.

He slips past the tiger's attack, leaps upward, and strikes down from above.

Golden sparks scatter as white fur and cold steel collide. The strike has forced open a hairline cut in the tiger's hardened hide, but the blade is now lodged in it.

Chéng grips the blade's hilt, closes his eyes, and draws in a deep breath.

Cheng Heguang: Sense the flow of Qi. Find the shuttle in the tiger's stomach. I can do this.

It takes a moment, but soon enough, he begins to feel the flow of Qi in the tiger's body.

Cheng Heguang: Through the muscles, I can feel it, the shuttle's unmistakable Qi.

The innards of this arcane creature have churned and tangled its Qi into a chaotic mass, one that Chéng fears he lacks the ability to unravel.

As he probes further, the Qi grows cold and dense, as if it were closing in around him.

Cheng Heguang: It's cold, like winter.

???: You fool of a boy! You are not to use your arcane skill again, do you hear me? Are you trying to get us all killed?

???: It's best you don't come to training tomorrow.

???: You're not selling the house anymore? Oh, I see. My condolences.

???: He's really dead?

???: An accident. Who'd have thought a military officer would be so fragile!

Cheng Heguang: No! No, no, no!

Snow drifts down onto the narrow courtyard. In Huanzhou, it seems the snow never truly ends.

Cheng Heguang: How can I find what he wants? Where do I even begin? I've already searched every corner of the courtyard.

Cheng Heguang: Mmm. But returning empty-handed would mean admitting defeat to Father, and I refuse to do that again.

The stubborn child turns his gaze toward the open gate and beyond.

Cheng Heguang: They told me never to go out there. That once I step through that gate, I'll never be able to come home again.

Cheng Heguang: But I have to. I have to go through it. Maybe what he wants is on the road, and if I can find a way out, then I can find a way back in.

He steels himself and takes a tentative step outside.

Father: Héguāng, trust your sense of Qi.
It will show you more than your eyes alone.

A slight tremor ripples beneath the snow.

Cheng Heguang: I found it! I found it!

Qi closes around the shape of something solid, and Chéng's eyes snap open.

The shuttle hardens in an instant, as though already clenched in his hand.

Cheng Heguang: ...!

He recalls what he learned as a child, hunting alongside the sons of wealthy families.

Cheng Heguang: Ahead of the stomach.

A piercing scream bursts forth from the tiger's throat as its struggles grow frantic.

Cheng Heguang: Angle inward above the foreleg, beneath the ribs. And ...

Cheng Heguang: Your heart is right here!

Tiger: *roar*

Chéng can no longer hold on as the tiger's death throes turn wild.

The tiger gives one last painful roar and thrashes across the ground before stillness takes it.

The now-metallic shuttle bursts through the tiger's chest and rolls to a stop beside Chéng.

Doctor Xiu: Nicely done. *gasp*

Doctor Xiù staggers up to him, laboring to guide her silver thread to stitch the gushing wound on her right arm.

Doctor Xiu: Are you able to stand?

Chéng forces a faint smile and sucks in a sharp breath of cold air.

Some time later, torchlight begins to flicker along the forest's edge. The village guards have finally arrived, fully armed and ready.

Hunter: I've brought help!

Headman: I thought you said there was a tiger? Where, huh? It's dead?

Fine snow drifts down like fuzzy willow catkins.

Winter is drawing to a close.

The Celebration

CH34701-07

The final gasp of winter snow falls, eventually giving way to clear skies.

For this impoverished village, such a celebration is rare. Every household gathers in Master Hú's courtyard, drinking deeply and eating meat by the mouthful.

Rumor has it that this is all thanks to Doctor Xiù's mediation, marking it a feast to celebrate the slaying of the tiger and to pray for a plentiful harvest in the year to come.

Hunter: Make way! Our young hero is here!

Young Man: A toast to you, my friend!

The moment Chéng steps into the courtyard, several hunters block his way with raised bowls of wine.

Cheng Heguang: There's no need for that. I merely did what I could.

Hunter: There's no need to be so polite! Come, sit, have a drink with us! It'd be rude not to.

Cheng Heguang: I don't care for drinking.

Young Man: Drink! Drink! Drink!

Hunter: Yeah! Go on!

Doctor Xiù hides behind a nearby pillar, quietly chuckling to herself.

Doctor Xiu: Hah. Hopefully that will get him to loosen up a bit.

Little Girl: Doctor! Doctor! My belly hurts!

A little girl tugs at the doctor's sleeve, looking up at her with tear-filled eyes.

She squats down, presses gentle fingers on her pulse, and slips a sugar-bound pill into her hand.

Doctor Xiu: It's nothing to worry over, child. Take this sweet little pill, and you'll feel better in no time.

Little Girl: Thank you, Doctor!

Doctor Xiù lifts her eyes to see a deep-blue-clad figure sitting along the edge of the black roof tiles.

Doctor Xiu: That boy ... Can he really not enjoy any sort of celebration?

She climbs the ladder up to the eaves, one step at a time.

Doctor Xiu: *sigh* Even I need a ladder to get up to the roof these days.

Cheng Heguang: There are too many people down there. I did only my duty. There's no need for all this gratitude.

Cheng Heguang: I saw the tiger fall into a ravine. How was it able to survive?

Doctor Xiu: Such things are rare, but not unheard of.

Doctor Xiu: Perhaps it was not a tiger at all, but instead a beast possessed, controlled by some arcane means, or perhaps it was some manner of mindless spirit.

Doctor Xiu: I heard once that, a long time ago, a horse once jumped off a cliff only to find a great fortune, even ascending to immortality!

Cheng Heguang: Please!

Doctor Xiù opens her wine jar and sits cross-legged beside him.

Doctor Xiu: I tell you no lies. Who can truly explain matters of the arcane?

Doctor Xiu: Anyway, I'm here to inform you that the clinic hasn't had a patient for three days now. You should seize this opportunity while it lasts. Remember my words about waiting for the perfect moment to strike?

Doctor Xiu: Her right sleeve hangs empty, the torn hem still unrepaired, giving her a slightly disheveled appearance.

Chéng grips his left hand tightly, lost in thought.

Doctor Xiu: What's wrong? Can't make up your mind?

Doctor Xiu: Credentials, hmm, I must ask, why do you wish so dearly to become an official?

Cheng Heguang: To overshadow my father's name with my own.

Cheng Heguang: One morning, he left and never returned.

Cheng Heguang: Since then, our family has faced nothing but trouble. At one time, the residents even surrounded us.

Doctor Xiu: Why not simply move away?

Cheng Heguang: After the incident, many of my family couldn't stand the gossip and returned to their lives in the countryside.

Cheng Heguang: "But we cannot give in to those people, and we can't run from this stain on our name."

Cheng Heguang: "Don't bother with the rumors. Don't bother with those who try to kick you when you're down."

Cheng Heguang: One day, I will prove our family's innocence.

The sound of the villagers' laughter floats on the breeze.

Doctor Xiu: Hah, but you were innocent all along.

Doctor Xiu: In truth, it was my fault.

Doctor Xiu: She takes a swig of wine, her voice growing hoarse.

Doctor Xiu: Many died that year, but the granary was still heavily guarded. Without an inside man, it would have been almost impossible to succeed.

Doctor Xiu: I asked your father for help. I told him we only had a handful of people, that we needed to strike during the guard change, grab some grain and maybe a few wen, then go.

Doctor Xiu: He took a leave of absence to distance himself, pinning all the blame on me and using the bandit attacks as a cover. It didn't cause much of a stir. No one spent much time on it.

Doctor Xiu: At most, he took the blame for negligence. It was simply a good deed, done without a second thought.

Cheng Heguang: But more than just a handful of refugees came that night.

Doctor Xiu: When word spread, everyone argued to come along and grab a bag of rice for themselves.

Doctor Xiu: I figured I needed the help. After all, how much could I carry on my own? It was truly only ever meant to be a few more pairs of hands.

Doctor Xiu: I only wanted to help as many people as I could.

The people below link arms, their voices rising in clamor.

The little girl, who only moments ago had taken medicine for her stomach, chases her friends in the courtyard.

Doctor Xiu: We entered the city and found ourselves at a merchant's house. Some were so taken with the black tiles and white walls that they refused to move on. I was eager to get the grain and leave, so I took a few of my most trusted men directly to the granary.

Doctor Xiu: By the time I returned, the situation had already spiraled out of control.

Doctor Xiu: Fires, yelling, and screaming. I watched my friends break into houses and come out with hands full of jewelry.

Doctor Xiu: I shouted, "Are you out of your minds?!"

Doctor Xiu: Are you out of your minds?!

She laughs loudly, spraying a mouthful of wine.

Doctor Xiu: They said, "We're stuck outside the city, starving and freezing, trudging along dirty roads. What right do these people have to sit in the city, feasting in their fine halls?"

Cheng Heguang: Like what I saw when I first arrived here.

Doctor Xiu: Hah, indeed.

Doctor Xiu: I stopped a few, urging them to hurry along. We still had to go back and hand out the grain.

Doctor Xiu: But most refused to listen!

Doctor Xiu: From then on, I told myself that those white houses held some sort of evil magic; otherwise, how could they lure good people to their doom?

Doctor Xiu: After all, they all died in the end.

A burst of noise erupts from under the eaves.

Young Man: See? I told you I could make fire!

Little flames dance at his fingers, and a steady fire burns in the middle of the courtyard.

Looking down from the roof, the flames seem as though they are scorching the houses. Or is it that they only cast a warm orange glow on their faces?

A proud laugh from the young man sets the children off, while the elders frown in disapproval. Doctor Xiù tosses her wine jug aside, hops to her feet, and lets out a hearty laugh of her own.

At the sound of her voice, the people turn their gaze upwards.

Doctor Xiu: Burn it! Burn it all! Burn down the house! Burn down the walls!

Doctor Xiu: The houses were burned to blackened ruins, but rice grew in abundance from the fertile soil!

Stern Guard: Doctor, what are you talking about?

Hunter: Haha, the doctor's drunk! She's playing at being a general again!

Young Man: Hey! Why are you putting it out?! Ugh!

With the flames fizzled out, the surrounding houses return to their original dreary state.

Doctor Xiù sits back down, leaning against the rooftiles and looking extremely drunk.

Doctor Xiu: I'll go with you tomorrow.

Cheng Heguang: No.

Chéng unclenches his fist. The iron shuttle hovers three inches above his palm, its surface marked with faint bloodstains.

Perhaps it was due to the tiger's strange Qi, but the effect of his arcane skill had not faded. Instead, it had permanently turned the bone shuttle to metal.

Cheng Heguang: Shuttlebones is dead.

Cheng Heguang: The people here need you.

Doctor Xiu: ...!

Intermediary: Commander Chéng, while this house may not match the grandeur of noble estates, it is a century-old building embodying both quiet wisdom and integrity!

Intermediary: Look at these walls. They have stood for many long years and are as sturdy and white as ever!

Father: Hmm. I've looked it over a few times now, and it is quite impressive.

Cheng Heguang: It's beautiful! Though, a little cramped. I'm not certain I'll have the room to swing my sword.

Mother: Ah, still devoted to your training? Your ambition never ceases to amaze me, Héguāng. I just know you'll be an excellent martial artist someday.

Cheng Heguang: It's too close to the ancestral hall. Just the thought of that place makes my knees hurt all over again.

Father: That's your fault for being such a mischief-maker! Besides, there are far worse punishments than kneeling for two hours a day.

Mother: Come now, there's really nothing wrong with the size. Let's just try to be content with the place. What's the use of all that space, anyway?

Father: Too true. Let's sign the deed today.

Intermediary: Excellent! Excellent!

Intermediary: Oh my, look at those flowers flying through the air!

Father: Héguāng!

Intermediary: Oh, it's no trouble at all! The young master's magics are truly impressive, like scattering golden flowers to celebrate your new home!

Intermediary: And I must say congratulations once more! You've made the right choice!

Intermediary: May your home be blessed with peace, your family flourish, and wealth fill your halls!

The Cage

CH34701-08

Foundation Office

A door at the far end of the hallway shuts, blocking out the muffled sounds of conversation.

As the four-hundred-year-old tale comes to an end, its listener scratches her head.

Paper Heron: So, after that, you went back to Zhu County and became a constable?

Chéng shakes his head.

Cheng Heguang: For some reasons, I failed to become a constable that year.

Cheng Heguang: I gave the iron shuttle to Lì Huìfēng, and he only smiled.

Paper Heron: But when I met you, it seemed you'd already been a constable for quite some time. Arresting people, shouting orders—you were actually rather skilled at it!

Cheng Heguang: I was lucky. Three years later, another constable position opened up. I succeeded in filling it.

Paper Heron: Hm?

Paper Heron: So, this story of yours has something to do with this box?

A finely crafted wooden box rests on the wooden table in the middle of the room. The lid has been removed and placed beside it.

Inside is a bill of exchange, listing the Hú family in the capital, and an amount of ten thousand taels of silver.

It also reads: "Bestowed upon Doctor Xiù, presented to Chéng Héguāng."

Paper Heron: Interesting. The East Asia branch just told me they had an old artifact in their warehouse, one that's been lying around for centuries.

Paper Heron: I heard it had once belonged to the Hú family, with specific instructions to pass it on to a man named Chéng Héguāng, possessor of a rather unique arcane skill.

Paper Heron: But where would we find someone to honor it? Surely they've all long forgotten about this thing by now.

Cheng Heguang: I've never heard of anything like this before. So much has happened since then. I never returned to that Riverside Village.

Paper Heron: Ah! With all this money, were you still in Huanzhou, you'd be living a life of leisure with not a care in the world.

Paper Heron: But now times have changed. The Hú family is long gone.

And the once valuable bill of exchange is just another useless scrap of paper.

Paper Heron: But why would she gift you all this?

Cheng Heguang: ...

Cheng Heguang: I don't know. I suppose now I never will.

Paper Heron suddenly smiles, as if recalling something. She paces back and forth twice before finally walking to the door.

Paper Heron: This elder ... Perhaps all she wanted was for you to live an unworried life.

Paper Heron: Either way, I've done what was asked of me. I'll be on my way. Thank you for the story, Héguāng.

The door closes, and Chéng is left standing alone in the room.

Cheng Heguang: ...

Side Room, Clinic

Doctor Xiu: Are you leaving?

Chéng nods as he finishes packing up his bundle.

Cheng Heguang: Matters are settled here. I need to head back right away.

Doctor Xiu: Here, take this medicine. It'll help with her cough.

Cheng Heguang: Thank you.

Doctor Xiu: I'm surprised you're letting me go.

Doctor Xiu: I thought, at the very least, you'd resent me for what happened with your father.

Cheng Heguang: He made his decision. And he took responsibility for his actions.

Doctor Xiu: Sometimes I think you're much more alike to us bandits than your vaunted officials.

Chéng puts the medicine in his bag and stops for a moment.

Cheng Heguang: Do not misunderstand me. If you return to banditry, I will show you no mercy.

Cheng Heguang: It doesn't matter what anyone's intentions were. Things happened as they did, and everyone has paid the price.

Cheng Heguang: Your price is to be a doctor, and mine is to be a constable. It is for the best.

Doctor Xiu: You had no hand in all this. It's not your fault. You are not your father.

Cheng Heguang: I know, but that changes little.

Doctor Xiu: You probably think me a rambler by now, but ...

Doctor Xiu: Why not stay in the village, hm? Live the life of a tiger-slaying hero? Why go back and put up with all that scrutiny?

Cheng Heguang: The offer is tempting. Slaying that tiger was indeed exhilarating.

But what do titles and glory matter to a hero that has more than himself to think of?

One who has a beautiful white house in Zhu County, where his mother still lives. One who is the son of Chéng. It is that hero's duty to protect that little white house.

And how can he leave before the walls are repainted white?

Cheng Heguang: In the end, I'll always be the son of a bandit.

Doctor Xiu: Constable or bandit, they're only words.

Cheng Heguang: They're more than just words. They're a gateway to the martial arts, to handfuls of silver, and to life-saving medicine.

"Just as the art enjoyed by the elite and the common folk differs, so does their etiquette. Outside the home, one listens to teachers and superiors; inside the home, one follows the manners of one's mother."

The people of the county hold the works of sages and scholars as unquestionable truth.

"One must hold compassion and kindness for others, even when in crisis. One must carry integrity, justice, and honesty, even when in poverty."

But none of them hail the brute who saved the village from a tiger.

Cheng Heguang: True righteousness can only be delivered through true righteous acts.

Cheng Heguang: When I become a constable, I will be fair and do right by the people. This I swear.

Cheng Heguang: Were I in charge of the militia here, I never would have let that tiger wreak havoc for so long, and I wouldn't have let any people die.

Cheng Heguang: Nor would I have let those refugees starve. None of this would have happened.

Doctor Xiu: You'll need to be a great general if you're to stop it from ever happening again.

Cheng Heguang: Once I become a constable, I will rise through the ranks: militia captain, regional commander ... Becoming a general will be within my grasp!

Doctor Xiu: If only all it took were grand words, eh? But that's not how the world works.

Doctor Xiu: She shakes her head.

Doctor Xiu: But then again, if you can truly live a life of wealth and glory, I suppose that's not such a bad compromise.

She smiles, a hint of melancholy in the curve of her mouth.

Doctor Xiu: Officials have always had beautiful homes. Perhaps your parents hoped as much for you.

Doctor Xiu: But should things go awry someday, you know where to find me.

Doctor Xiu: I'll help you.

Zhu County looks just as it did before. The streets are filled with pretty houses, one on top of the other, and all topped with black tiles.

Cheng Heguang: Constable and bandit are only words.

Cheng Heguang: I've been away for so long. I wonder how things are at home.

Chéng passes beneath three Paifang, and the familiar sight of his home comes into view.

Cheng Heguang: ...!

Mother: That year, I had planned to sell the house and set aside some money. Those who came to look all praised it, calling the courtyard splendid and the house magnificent.

Mother: A good house keeps its wealth hidden. You'd never know whether it was filled with gold and jewels or rolls of the finest silks.

Mother: *cough* They walked in full of envy but left sighing and grumbling.

Mother: Because there was nothing to be found in our house.

???: Because a tomb is a house for the dead.

???: And a home can be the same for the living.

This ancient house has played host to countless masters, and now it adds one more to its history.

A long white banner flutters in the wind, scattering the red Mei blossoms on the ground.

Another gust of wind blows into the room, sweeping away the thin, pale bill of exchange.

Cheng Heguang: ...

Cheng Heguang: Seeking victory in the wrong place only invites further misfortune.

The bill floats out the window, soaring higher and further like a bird in flight.

Until it goes beyond the range of his arcane skill, becoming a barely visible white dot in the distance.

Paper Heron pokes her head around the door.

Paper Heron: Oops. My memory's terrible, you know! There's something else I forgot to mention.

Paper Heron: I bumped into some folk from the East Asia branch of the Vigiles Bureau. They're looking to recruit you.

Paper Heron: You know of them, right? Their job is like that of a constable's: catching thieves, writing reports, and that sort of thing.

Paper Heron: Anyway, I'm just passing along their message. So, what do you think?

Chéng looks at the empty box. A barely perceptible smile crosses his face.

Cheng Heguang: Let's talk about it later.

He remembers an old house. A white house.

A house that welcomes life into the world. A house that bids farewell to those who pass.

A house that has laid to rest Father, Mother, and friends.

A house with clearly defined edges, square and stern in its form.

A house consumed by fierce flames.

Cheng Heguang: I could never find what I'm seeking in that home.

Cheng Heguang: So I burned it down and left.